

1. PURPOSE AND SCOPE

- 1.1 This document provides a general introduction about ASI Assurances Services International GmbH (ASI) ([Section 5](#)), describes the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program ([Section 6](#)) and the transition process (for ASI accredited CABs) to be recognized under the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program ([Section 7](#)).
- 1.2 This document also establishes participation requirements for Accreditation Bodies (ABs) operating under the framework of Regulation (EC) 765/2008 in the European Economic Area (EEA) and of UKAS operating under the Regulation on Accreditation and Market Surveillance No 765:2008 (GB RAMS) in the UK, and ASI North America PB LLC (ASI North America), interested in establishing a cooperation with ASI to provide Accreditation for any of the Voluntary Sustainability Standards (VSS) that ASI provides oversight for (hereinafter Scheme Owners (SOs)) under the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program ([Section 8](#)).

2. CHANGE HISTORY

Version number	Date of approval	Description of changes
1.0	01 December 2020	First publication
1.1	14 December 2021	Revised requirements for AB participation in ASI Two Tier program
2.0	09 August 2022	Minor revisions in line with the creation of the ASI Approvals Procedure to avoid repetitions (previous section 7.4 - Application for new CABs not part of the ASI system- has been moved to Approval Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-258)).
2.1	10 April 2024	Format changes to match new ASI branding. No content changes.
2.2	27 May 2024	Due to technical problems, hyperlinks to other documents are removed.

3. TERMS AND DEFINITIONS

- 3.1 All terms and definitions, not listed below, are provided in the ASI Glossary (ASI-INF-20-100).
- 3.2 **ASI Approval (Decision):** ASI confirmation that the CAB complies with the ASI Approval Requirements and SO Requirements and can provide certification services within, provided that the CAB also holds a valid Accreditation from a Participating AB as per the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program.

Explanatory Note [SOURCE: IAF MD 25]: SO Authorization of a CAB: SO authorization means that the SO accepts certificates, reports, statements or attestations issued by a CAB for the purposes of confirming that the object of the conformity assessment meets the requirements of its CAS. SOs may use different wording to denote/state/describe authorization, such as listing, approval, recognition, designation, etc.

- 3.3 **ASI Approval Certificate:** Certificate issued by ASI to confirm compliance with the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program.
- 3.4 **ASI Approval Requirements** means those requirements which are set up by ASI and which the CAB has to fulfill to qualify for being approved to a Certification Scheme and for maintaining such approval. These are contained in the documents (information documents,

policies, procedures and templates) listed in ASI-INF-20-120 'Controlled List of Public ASI QMS Documents' and published on ASI's website (www.asi-assurance.org/s/quality).

- 3.5 **ASI North America PB LLC** (ASI NA), is a wholly owned subsidiary with limited liabilities of FSC AC, constituted as Delaware LLC, the Participating AB appointed to accredit CABs with head offices based outside the EEA and UK.
- 3.6 **ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program:** The ASI program that integrates Accreditation (Tier One) and complementary ASI Assurance Services (Tier Two) to ensure the overall integrity for Scheme Owners and their claims:
- ⇒ **Tier One:** Consists of the Accreditation of Conformity Assessment Bodies (CABs) by Participating Accreditation Bodies (Participating ABs) with mandatory ASI participation in Accreditation Assessments, leading to an Accreditation Decision.
 - ⇒ **Tier Two:** Consists of the complementary Assurance Services provided by ASI, leading to an ASI Approval Decision.
- 3.7 **Assurance Services:** Any and all independent and impartial ASI Assessment or other relevant activities that ensure the integrity of Scheme Owner's systems and their claims.
- 3.8 **Participating Accreditation Body** (Participating AB): Participating AB operating under the framework of (EC) 765/2008 in the European Economic Area (EEA) and of UKAS operating under the regulation on Accreditation and Market Surveillance No 765:2008 (GB RAMS) in the UK and ASI North America PB LLC that has established a cooperation with ASI to provide Accreditation for any of the Scheme Owners under the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program.
- 3.9 **Scheme Owners** (also ASI Client VSS) means ASI partner Voluntary Sustainability Standards (VSS) and sustainability initiatives, which have exclusively appointed ASI to provide Assurance Services on their behalf under the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program.
- 3.10 **Scheme Owner (SO) Requirements** means those Requirements which are set up by the Scheme Owner of the relevant Scheme, for which CABs have to comply in order to provide the relevant certification services. These are contained in documents (e.g. standards, policies, procedures, advice notes etc.) published by the Scheme Owner. As far as these documents incorporate other publicly available documents by reference (e.g. ISO standards), further requirements set up in such other documents are also considered part of the SO Requirements.

4. ASSOCIATED DOCUMENTATION

4.1	Procedures, Guidelines	ASI-INF-20-100-Glossary ASI-PRO-20-258-Approval
4.2	Checklists, Templates, etc.	ASI Assurance Service Agreement (ASA) ASI-TPL-20-240-ASI-Two-Tier Assurance Program Application Form

5. ABOUT ASI

- 5.1 ASI is an Assurance partner for leading VSS and sustainability initiatives around the world. ASI started as an international Accreditation Body for a single VSS and over the years, evolved into an "assurance provider" for multiple leading VSS, delivering a broader spectrum of credible Assurance Services tailored to clients' needs.

- 5.2 ASI has been exclusively appointed by ASI Client VSS to oversee the integrity and credibility of their Certification Schemes worldwide and the claims made under them in partnership with Participating ABs.

6. ASI TWO-TIER ASSURANCE PROGRAM

- 6.1 ASI has developed the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program to be implemented together with Participating ABs. This program integrates Accreditation (Tier One) and complementary ASI Assurance Services (Tier Two) to ensure the overall integrity of Scheme Owners (SOs) and their claims.
- 6.2 **Tier One** consists of Accreditation for relevant harmonized standards (i.e. ISO 17065 or ISO 17021) and is undertaken by Participating ABs that have established a cooperation agreement with ASI, and that comply with the AB participation requirements set by ASI ([Section 7](#)). Tier One requires the mandatory participation of ASI Assessors during Accreditation Assessments. This participation is accrued against ASI sampling levels and the Annual Service Fee (ASF).
- 6.3 **Tier Two** consists of complementary and mandatory ASI Assurance Services such as Assurance Assessments that go beyond the basal Accreditation sampling under ISO 17011 and other services that allow ASI to ensure that Scheme Owner (SO) Requirements are consistently and rigorously met globally and that systems accredited under Tier One are effectively implemented.

Note 1: Details of which ABs are currently participating in the ASI Two Tier Assurance Program can be found here: <https://www.asi-assurance.org/s/oversight-and-accreditation/asi-two-tier-assurance-program>

Note 2: ASI intends to implement the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program for all CABs worldwide.

7. ASI APPROVAL PROCESS

- 7.1 Any CAB wishing to provide certification services for one or more SOs within the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program shall first be approved by ASI.
- 7.1.1 CABs which do not hold an ASI accreditation at the time of application shall follow the process for new CABs detailed in the ASI Approval Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-258). This is summarized in [Annex 1](#) of this document.
- 7.1.2 CABs which are transitioning from an existing ASI accreditation to the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program, shall follow the requirements under 7.3 below. If the CAB decides not to participate in the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program, ASI will have to terminate the existing ASI Assurance Service Agreement (ASA).
- 7.2 All information requested by ASI, including the application and supporting documentation shall be completed in English.
- 7.3 **Application (transition) for CABs already part of the ASI system (see [Annex 2](#))**
- 7.3.1 All ASI accredited CABs shall transition their accreditation into the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program. CABs in the EEA/UK shall transition to a Participating AB operating under Regulation (EC) 765:2008 or operating under the UKAS regulation on Accreditation and Market Surveillance No 765:2008 (GB RAMS). CABs with an

accredited entity outside the EEA or the UK shall transition their accreditation into the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program under ASI North America.

- 7.3.2 This transition shall start within 6 months after ASI and the Participating AB have contractually formalized their partnership in a particular country and issued a joint communication to this effect.
- 7.3.3 CABs wishing to continue offering services for SOs, shall sign a revision to their existing ASA and agree to the terms established within.
- 7.3.4 Once the ASA revision has been signed, ASI shall issue an Approval Letter to the CAB.
- 7.3.5 With this letter, the CAB shall apply to the Participating AB for initial Accreditation or for scope extension (if already accredited for ISO 17065 or ISO 17021) and follow the Participating AB processes.
- 7.3.6 The CAB shall undergo Accreditation Assessments conducted by the Participating AB.
 - 7.3.6.1 If the CAB is already accredited by the Participating AB and is only applying for scope extension, a shortened process may be offered. However, this is at the Participating AB's sole discretion.
- 7.3.7 After the Participating AB has issued the Accreditation Certificate, ASI shall issue the ASI Approval Certificate and the CAB can continue providing certification services under the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program.
- 7.3.8 The ASI Accreditation Certificate shall remain valid, until a new Accreditation Certificate has been issued by the Participating AB and an Approval Certificate has been issued by ASI.
- 7.3.9 For details of the requirements for maintaining approval and reapproval, please refer to the ASI Approval Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-258).

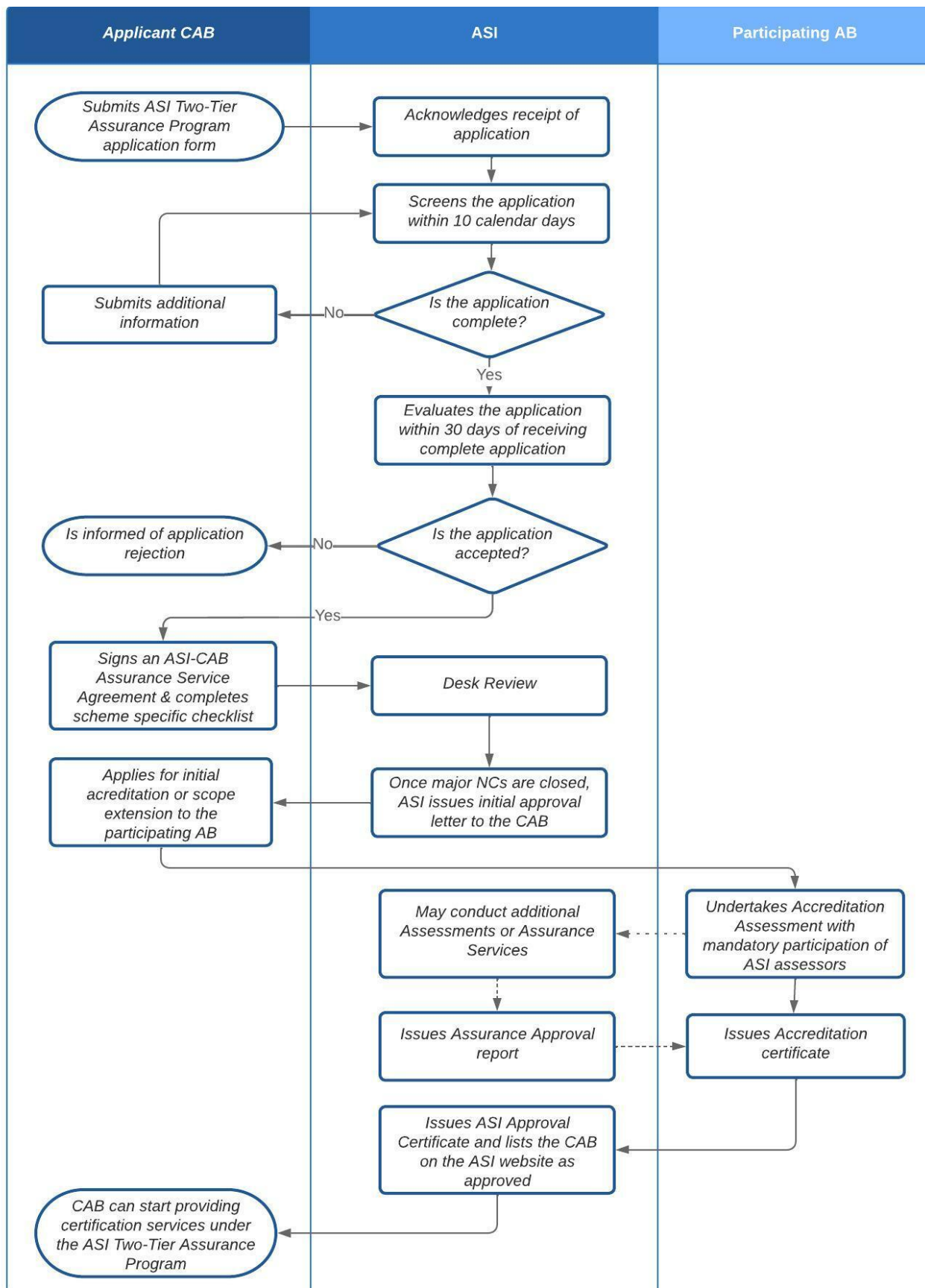
8. AB PARTICIPATION REQUIREMENTS

- 8.1 ASI has developed a set of requirements for Participating ABs interested in establishing a cooperation with ASI to provide Accreditation under the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program. Participating ABs shall recognize the spirit of this collaboration, which is to strengthen the integrity of the respective ASI Client VSS by reducing duplications in Accreditation oversight yet maintaining global perspective and rigor.
- 8.2 ASI shall formally announce to CABs in writing and on the ASI website any partnership established with Participating ABs.
- 8.3 The participation requirements supplement the requirements specified by the International Accreditation Forum (IAF) and the European Accreditation (EA) as well as the normative systems of ISO CASCO (17000) and do not contradict these.
- 8.4 A CAB with a Head Office (HO) in an EEA country for which no Participating AB has declared participation interest in the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program can choose any other Participating AB as foreseen by (EC) 765/2008 or GB RAMS. A CAB with a HO in a non-EEA / non-UK country shall apply for accreditation under the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program with ASI North America PB LC.

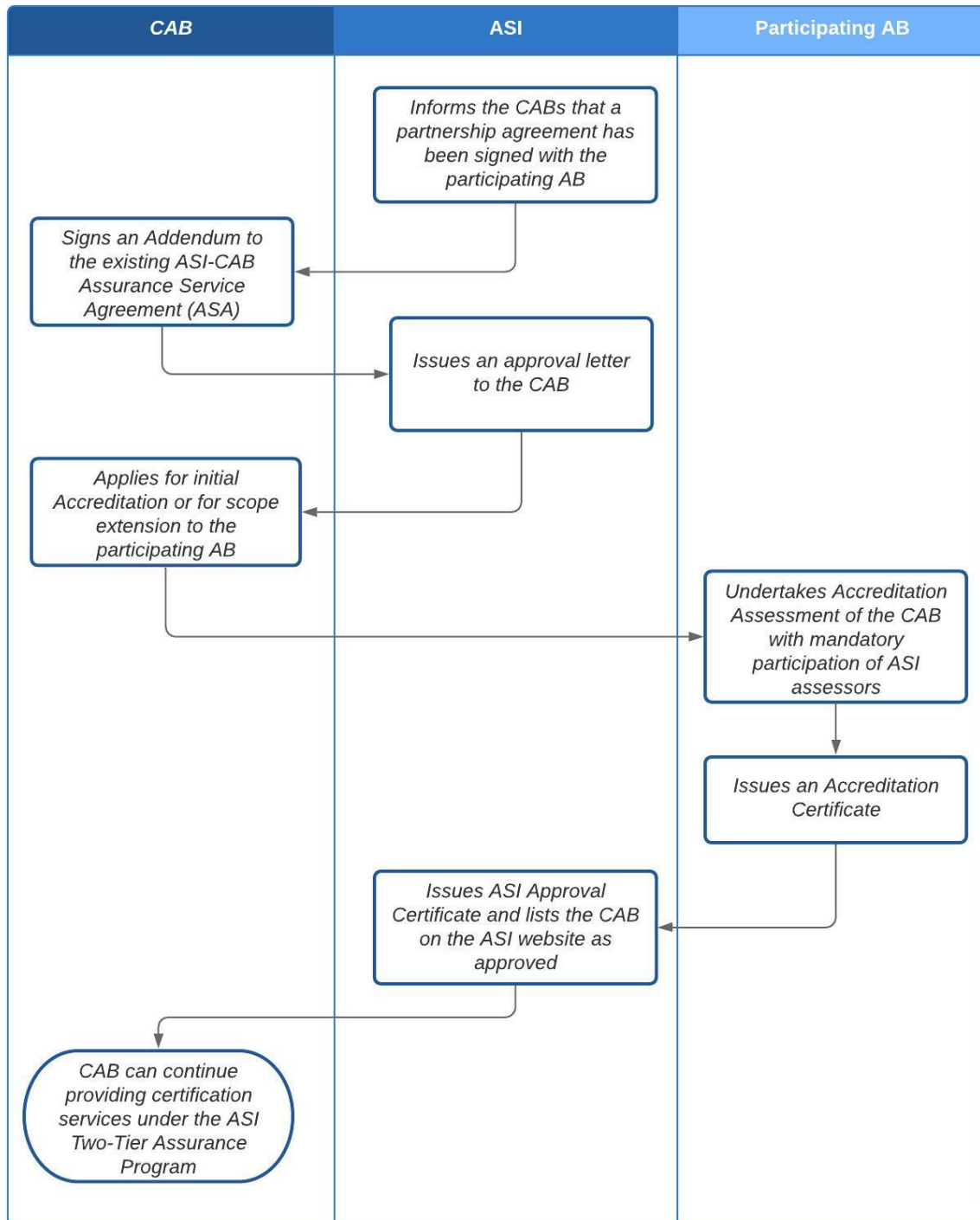
- 8.5 ASI and the Participating AB shall enter into a formal cooperation agreement that includes the requirements listed below. Additional requirements may apply, including but not limited to financial aspects, data protection and conflict of interest management:
- 8.5.1 The Participating AB shall recognize and agree that ASI is the sole point of contact with ASI Client VSS. SO relationship management includes but is not limited to:
 - 8.5.1.1 general administration of the SO's assurance program;
 - 8.5.1.2 general communication and reporting;
 - 8.5.1.3 participation in SO and CAB meetings;
 - 8.5.1.4 request for SO interpretations;
 - 8.5.1.5 dispute management according to ASI procedures;
 - 8.5.1.6 training of ASI assessors on SO Requirements.
 - 8.5.2 The Participating AB shall agree that ASI is the primary point of contact for CABs in relation to the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program.
 - 8.5.3 The Participating AB shall agree that the official working language is English. ASI may accept other languages upon request for day-to-day interaction. Any such exception can be revoked by ASI. Contractual matters as well as information on management of NCs shall be maintained in English (translations may be provided).
 - 8.5.4 The cooperation agreement is not time bound but is subject to regular review meetings. ASI reserves the right to terminate the agreement, should the exchange and collaboration be unsatisfactory.
 - 8.5.5 The Participating AB shall participate in annual experience exchanges and calibration meetings with ASI, with at least one Participating AB representative present.
 - 8.5.6 The Participating AB and ASI agree to inform each other with due notice, in case of any significant changes (e.g., organizational, personal) which may impact the AB participation.
 - 8.5.7 The Participating AB shall only accept applications for Accreditation, if and after the applicant CAB is accepted by ASI into the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program.
 - 8.5.8 The Participating AB Accreditation assessments shall include the mandatory participation of ASI Assessors.
 - 8.5.9 The Participating AB shall invite ASI to participate in relevant sector committees related to sustainability standards.
 - 8.5.10 The Participating AB shall not issue any initial Accreditation under the Two-Tier Assurance Program without considering confirmation from ASI that the Tier-Two requirements have been met.
 - 8.5.11 The Participating AB shall inform ASI with due notice in case of suspension or withdrawal of Accreditation, which shall also result in the suspension of ASI Approval for activities under Tier Two.
 - 8.5.11.1 A suspension of ASI Approval or other ASI issued sanctions shall be reviewed by the participating AB to consider similar sanctions of the Accreditation of CABs for the VSS scope (Tier One).

- 8.5.12 The Participating AB shall inform ASI about identified NCs for accredited CABs which may put the ability of the CAB to deliver impartial and competent certification services in question for scopes relevant to SOs.

Annex 1: ASI Application process for new applicants



Annex 2: ASI Transition process for ASI CABs



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